

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

SCOPE OF WORK

I. Purpose of Funding

The City of Austin (COA) seeks proposals from qualified Contractors to operate a City-owned South Austin Housing Navigation Center (SAHNC) for coordinated housing-focused navigation services to individuals and households at risk of homelessness or experiencing unsheltered homelessness.

Department: Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations (HSO)

Services Solicited: Housing Navigation Center Operations and Social Services

Available Funding: \$250,000 from the City of Austin House Our People Endowment (HOPE) Fund

Number of Agreements and Contract Term: The City anticipates awarding a single agreement starting October 1st, 2026 for a twelve-month term, with two potential renewal options. Proposals shall be submitted using the 12-month budget allocation. All future renewal options will be based on future budget availability. Collaborative Offers will be considered; however, a lead agency must be identified.

Minimum Request: Contractors may submit a proposal for less than the full amount available if RFA objectives are met. Awarded programs will be structured as a reimbursable agreement, as defined below:

Reimbursable Agreement- An Agreement where an agency is reimbursed for expenses incurred and paid through the provision of adequate supporting documentation that verifies the expenses.

Leveraged Funds: Competitive proposals will identify resources to match eligible expenses. Leveraged funds, or match, is defined as either cash and/or in-kind resources, such as volunteer hours, donated goods or services, or other funding sources to supplement the program.

Cash match must be identified in the budget, contributed to the program, and expended on eligible costs, as outlined in this RFA, and in the awarded contract.

In-kind match is the value of any real property, equipment, goods, or services contributed to the program, provided that, if the recipient/subrecipient had to pay for them with City funds, the costs would have been eligible. In-kind and cash match should be categorized in the budget as “Other Funding.”

Proposals for this solicitation that identify leverage of up to 20% or greater of the proposed budget will score more favorably as outlined in Question 22 of Exhibit H – RFA Evaluation Scoring Rubric Summary.

II. Term of Contract

This contract shall remain in effect for an initial term of twelve (12) months or the City terminates the contract. This contract may be extended beyond the initial term for up to two (2) additional twelve (12) month periods at the City’s sole option.

III. Background

The City of Austin is deeply committed to ending homelessness and has worked with community partners to assemble and coordinate investments across the Homelessness Response System (HRS). An effective crisis response system quickly identifies those experiencing homelessness, provides basic needs supports, and connects households to housing and support services that will resolve their homelessness.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

On August 14, 2024, Austin City Council passed [Resolution 20240814-026](#) that established the House Our People Endowment (HOPE) Fund to be used for capital and operating expenses related to housing and services to supplement the myriad of City efforts already underway related to homelessness. In the Fiscal Year 2025-2026 budget process Council designated the funding to be used for the Navigation Center. Funding for the HOPE fund is supported by Tourism Public Improvement District (TPID) tax levy and from delinquent tax fees.

While there are multiple navigation centers, day resource centers, drop-in centers, and triage case management operations within Austin, this solicitation will be HSO's first dedicated housing-focused navigation center project. As such, HSO has sought input from multiple stakeholders in the design and implementation of this solicitation.

The Housing Navigation Center will primarily connect individuals at risk of homelessness or experiencing homelessness with resources to reduce morbidity and premature mortality, engage clients in appropriate social safety net programs, and to address their immediate housing crisis. The Housing Navigation Center will address housing barriers and connect households to emergency shelter, permanent housing projects, such as rapid rehousing or permanent supportive housing, or fair market housing. Additionally, this facility will have spaces for other community providers, such as mental health, physical health, and employment providers, to meet with participants to increase the client's connections with larger systems of specialized care. Lastly, the Housing Navigation Center will offer emergency resources and aid to participants to reduce deaths on the streets.

IV. Minimum Qualifications

- Agency shall be a non-profit organization or quasi-governmental entity able to conduct business in the State of Texas and legally contract with the City of Austin.
- Agencies, board of directors, and/or leadership staff submitting a proposal shall have a minimum of two years established, and successful experience providing services to individuals or households experiencing homelessness.
- Agency shall have submitted all applicable tax returns to the IRS and the State of Texas (e.g., Form 990 or 990-EZ as well as state and federal payroll tax filings).
- Agency shall be current in its payment of Federal and State payroll taxes.
- Agency shall be eligible to contract and are not debarred from contracting with the City of Austin, State of Texas or Federal government, according to SAM.gov, and State and City debarment information.
- Agency cannot owe past due taxes to the City of Austin or Travis County.
- Agency shall have the ability to meet City of Austin, Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations' standard agreement terms and conditions, which includes Social Services Insurance Requirements.
- Agency shall have an active Board of Directors that meets regularly and reviews program performance, financial performance, and annually approves the agency budget. The Board of Directors shall have a strong commitment to fundraising to ensure well-funded, sustainable programs and operations.
- Collaborative Applications: Applicants who apply with a collaborative application must ensure that participant eligibility and assessment criteria, access to services and resources, and program design are uniform.
- Subcontracting: Costs associated with procuring eligible program services as outlined in this document from third party or contract vendors are eligible for this project.

V. Solicitation Requirements

A. Eligible Population

The population eligible for this project consists of:

1. Individuals or households who are "At Risk of Homelessness." For the purpose of this project, the definition of "At Risk of Homelessness" can be found at 24 CFR Part 576.2.

And

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

2. Individuals or households experiencing homelessness. For the purpose of this project, the definition and categories of “Homeless” can be found at 24 CFR Part 576.2.

B. Housing Navigation Shelter Services Solicited

Housing Navigation Centers are designed to provide navigation and resource services to resolve a household’s housing crisis. A successful Housing Navigation Center program will assist participants to attain permanent or temporary housing, connect to specialized systems of care, and provide emergency resources to reduce the likelihood of death on the streets.

1) Facilities and Capacity:

South Austin Housing Navigation Center: This facility is a two-story, 12,000 square foot office building located at 2401 S I-35, Austin, Texas 78741

- This facility does NOT currently have public hygiene capacity or commercial kitchen equipment.
- The City of Austin has invested in updates to the HVAC, exterior electrical, ADA compliance, Permanent fencing, security cameras, and a hot water replacement.
- The City of Austin will provide funding for large facility repairs and maintenance, but the chosen operator will be responsible for maintaining the functional operations of the facility.

C. Eligible Costs

Below is a list of services and activities that may be paid for using HSO’s housing navigation center agreement (“eligible costs”). Services or activities not found in this list are not reimbursable unless the COA Homeless Strategies and Operations Director or their designee has provided written approval. Costs associated with personnel and equipment needed to carry out the services or activities are also eligible.

- i. **Navigation Operations:** Services and equipment necessary to facilitate the day-to-day operations of the Navigation Center. This may include assisting participants in accessing and utilizing services, checking into the facility, addressing immediate participant concerns, providing hygiene material and emergency clothing to participants, de-escalating incidents, enforcing facility rules and expectations, and ensuring the successful utilization of amenities.
- ii. **Transportation Assistance:** Cost of transportation for participants, such as travel on public transportation or shuttle services to major transportation hubs, to/from eligibility assessment, medical care, employment, childcare, or other services eligible under this section. Cost associated with the purchase or lease of vehicles for the purpose of the project may be allowable with written contract manager approval.
- iii. **Emergency Supplies:** Supplies, resources, and equipment provided to participants to address immediate and short-term basic needs to increase engagement and reduce morbidity and mortality. Such items may include, but are not limited to, ID cost assistance, emergency snacks, clothing, hygiene kits, shoes, mobility assistance equipment, and equipment necessary to prevent exposure and weather-related injury, in compliance with local ordinance and state law.
- iv. **Facility Operations:** Operator shall maintain facility in accordance with COA Code, to ensure the safe utilization with appropriate access, space, security, air quality, water, sanitary conditions, and fire safety. To this end, eligible costs include the costs of maintenance (including minor or routine repairs), security, fuel, equipment, insurance, utilities, furnishings, and supplies necessary for the operation of the facility.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

- v. **Data Entry:** Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) user licenses and any equipment and training needed to actively contribute to and utilize information within the local HMIS or other systems necessary to complete reporting requirements.
- vi. **Administrative Activities:** Contractor may use up to 10% of the project budget for administrative costs related to the planning and administration of the project. Activities include preparing program budgets and schedules, developing systems to manage compliance with the program requirements, monitoring program activities for progress and compliance with program requirements, and preparing reports and other documents directly related to the program for submission to the City. Administrative activities do not include staff and overhead costs directly related to carrying out activities or services of the program. Administrative activities do not include indirect costs, which are not eligible for reimbursement in HSO Contracts.

D. Operational Requirements

- i. **In General:** Operators shall establish and maintain standard operating procedures to ensure these requirements are met. Operators shall establish and maintain sufficient records to allow the City to determine compliance with both this document and their contract with the City.
- ii. **Participant Eligibility Recordkeeping Requirements**
 - a. Projects shall maintain documentation of participant eligibility for services at project entry.
 - b. For individuals who are determined ineligible for project enrollment, operators shall maintain documentation of the determination and the reason for that determination.
- iii. **Facility Management and Operations**

As operator of the navigation center, the Contractor is responsible for overall operations, maintenance, and oversight of the facility and the activities located therein.

 - a. The defined premise shall operate for a minimum of 30 hours per week.
 - b. There will be no fee charged to participants to access services of the facility.
 - c. Facilities shall meet the Austin Code Compliance requirements. Operators will proactively work with HSO staff to address facility maintenance issues, especially severe issues impacting operations and utilization of the facility.
 - a. Operator shall provide routine facility operations including but not limited to: mechanical systems, electrical systems, plumbing systems, life safety systems, elevators and lifts, building envelop and grounds, and general interior and common areas.
 - b. Operator shall provide custodial services and maintain orderly and tidy conditions.
 - c. Operator shall, whenever possible, use registered City of Austin vendors and pre-approved or established contractors to perform maintenance, custodial and facility repairs. Any exceptions shall require prior written approval from the City.
 - d. Operator shall establish and implement a written Preventative Maintenance program and maintain accurate records of all maintenance and repair activities.
 - e. Operator is not responsible for capital replacements, structural repairs. Single item repairs or costs over \$5,000 require prior approval. HSO retains the right to conduct facility inspections when it deems necessary.
 - f. Other operator requirements may be established and negotiated upon award of contract.
 - d. Operator shall ensure service delivery and facility access is conducted in accordance with the City of Austin's Anti-discrimination Ordinance, Chapter 5-1 Housing Discrimination, Americans with Disabilities Act regulations, and federal Fair Housing regulations and core statutory protections of the Violence Against Women Act (VAWA) under [24 CFR part 5, subpart L](#). Operators shall provide reasonable accommodations to meet participant's disability needs.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

- c. Operator shall establish security measures, collaboratively developed with participants, which ensure spaces are safe for staff and participants.
- d. Operator shall ensure a sanitary environment, free from pests or rodent infestations.
- e. Operator shall maintain a designated smoking area provided on-site.
- f. Operator shall allow participants to receive services with their pets.
- g. Operator shall maintain appropriate space and equipment for participants to receive mail at the location.
- h. Operator shall maintain appropriate space and equipment for participants to store and access medications. The operator must ensure compliance with relevant storage requirements and must coordinate with medical partners to ensure safety standards are adhered to.
- i. Operator shall provide sufficient space for Integral Care's Mobile Clinic, Community Care Street Medic team, and other community providers to meet with participants. Operators will work with these other providers to establish a consistent weekly schedule.

iv. Service Delivery

- a. To the greatest extent possible, projects shall provide supportive services to all participants. Services may be designed by the operator. Operator shall conduct regular assessments of the supportive services needed by participants, the availability of such services, and the coordination of services needed to quickly connect clients to temporary and permanent housing. Operator will make adjustments to services offered and/or service plans, as appropriate.
- b. Documentation of service delivery is required in HMIS, and programs should actively engage participants from the time of intake to avoid delays in creating a service plan.

v. Neighborhood Involvement

- a. Operator will comply with HSO's [Good Neighbor Provisions](#).
- b. Operator shall actively cultivate a collaborative relationship with neighboring community members and business leaders as evidenced by participating in neighborhood advisory boards (i.e. the South Austin Housing Navigation Center Advisory Board), neighborhood associations, and local business associations.
- c. It is required of operators to proactively engage individuals experiencing unsheltered homelessness within a 1,000-foot radius of the facilities to assist in either accessing HSO's shelter referral processes or exiting homelessness.
- d. Operator shall engage in litter abatement within a 500-foot radius of the facility.
- e. Operator will support the coordination of services for participants involved with other community providers. Activities may include providing space for service provision and meetings, coordinating communication, and involving co-facilitating case management meetings with the provider.

vi. Program Participant Records

- a. Operator shall document participants' continued eligibility for services through annual assessments of participants' needs and services received.
- b. Operator shall document that participants have been informed of their rights and responsibilities as program participants, the responsibilities of the operator, the services available to the participant, and the policies and processes for grievance and termination.
- c. Operator shall document that participants have been informed of their right to submit grievances, the process to submit a grievance, the outcome of grievance determinations, and decisions resulting in involuntary termination from the program through the HSO Involuntary Termination Form submission.

vii. Participant and Partner Organization Feedback

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

- a. Operator shall solicit feedback from participants and partner organizations on at least a quarterly basis through one or more of the following channels: surveys, user advisory panel, focus groups, or town-hall meetings.
- b. Feedback shall assess the participants' opinions regarding project service delivery, housing needs, and supportive service needs towards successful project exit.
- c. Documentation of feedback, policies and procedures of the process, and programmatic changes responding to participant concerns shall be maintained by operators.

viii. Grievance

- a. Operator shall maintain a process for participants to formally protest decisions or operations that impact their service and/or living experience. Operator shall support participants in completing the grievance process if assistance is requested.
- b. Grievance submissions shall identify the decision or operation that the participant is protesting, and the operator shall respond with a decision within five business days of the grievance submission.
- c. The outcome of a grievance shall be determined by a member of the organization who neither provides services or directly supervises staff providing services to the protesting participant.
- d. In the event that there are no staff who may objectively determine the outcome of a grievance or at the request of the operator, the COA Homeless Strategies and Operations Director or their designee may determine the outcome of a grievance.
- e. Services to the participant may not be halted or terminated during the determination of a grievance outcome.
- f. Documentation of filed grievances and their outcomes shall be provided to HSO upon request.

ix. Termination

- a. Operators shall develop and maintain a formal termination policy in alignment with the Austin/ Travis County CoC Termination Policy.
- b. Participants who do not receive services for 90 days will be terminated from services.

x. Incident Reporting

- a. Operators will report critical events resulting in a call to 9-1-1, to Austin's Homeless Strategies and Operations at homeless.input@austintexas.gov. All incidents regarding emergency services must be reported within 24 hours.

xi. Administrative Costs Documentation

- a. Operators shall maintain documentation of all costs allocated to the "Administration" budget line item including staff time, equipment, rental or utility payment utilized for the administration of the project. Operators may cover the costs of facilities used for the delivery of services under the supportive services budget line item and administration line item proportional to the amount of space used for each.

VI. Data Collection and Reporting

Contractors shall comply with the following data requirements:

- a. Utilize the local Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) to track and report participant information and program services for individuals who are experiencing homelessness.
- b. Adhere to all requirements of Exhibit D: HMIS Reporting Requirements, including Continuum of Care (CoC) and related regulatory requirements.
- c. Data Security and Management: Operator shall ensure that all technology and data systems utilized in the operation of this program follow HMIS data security and management standards, ensuring the personally identifiable information is only accessible to appropriate program staff.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSD Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

VII. Reporting and Performance Outcomes

Contractors will complete proposed performance for a 12-month contracting cycle, and on a quarterly basis, be required to report the following:

Outputs	
Output #1	Unduplicated individuals served
Output #2	Unduplicated Households served (inclusive of single person households)
Output #3	Number of Households who complete a Coordinated Assessment (CA) through Navigation Center services
Output #4	Number of Households who obtain vital documents (ID, Birth certificates, driver's license, etc.) through Navigation Center services
Output #5	Number of Households who enroll in MAP through Navigation Center services
Outcomes	
Outcome #1	Percentage of Households referred to shelter Numerator: Number of Households referred to shelter Denominator: Unduplicated Households served
Outcome #2	Percentage of Households that exit to a positive housing destination Numerator: Number of Households who exit to a positive housing destination* Denominator: Unduplicated Households served

* A Positive Housing Destination is defined in alignment with HUD's [HMIS outcome for Street Outreach found in Appendix A](#)

A. Service Delivery Requirements

The navigation center **shall adhere** to the following principles:

- a. **Trauma-Informed Care:** Operator shall ensure service delivery and facility operations are in alignment with the [Principles of Trauma-Informed Care](#). A program, organization, or system that is trauma-informed realizes that widespread impact of trauma and understands potential paths for recovery; recognizes the signs and symptoms of trauma in participants, families, staff, and others involved in the system; and responds by fully integrating knowledge about trauma into policies, procedures, and practices, and seeks to actively minimize re-traumatization.
- b. **Language Access:** Operator shall offer language assistance, in writing and verbally, to all participants who have limited English proficiency and/or other communication needs, at no cost to them, to facilitate timely access to all services.
- c. **Civil Rights Regulations:** Operator shall ensure service delivery and facility access is conducted in accordance with the City of Austin's [Anti-discrimination Ordinance, Chapter 5-1 Housing Discrimination](#), federal Fair Housing regulations, and core statutory protections of the Violence Against Women Act (VAWA) under [24 CFR part 5, subpart L](#).
- d. **Reduce Duplication of Services:** Operator shall make every effort to ensure participants do not receive duplication of services or assistance from different funding sources.
- e. **Critical Time Intervention:** Operators shall utilize a CTI framework when conceptualizing and planning service delivery and the participant's service experience.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSD Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

B. Best Practices

All supportive services programs are encouraged to incorporate the following best practices, including, but not limited to:

- a. Culturally Competent Service Delivery: Contractors shall demonstrate a strong understanding of the needs of individuals and households experiencing homelessness and demonstrate a history of participant-centered care and culturally competent service delivery.
- b. Incorporating Perspectives from People with Lived Experience: All recipients of HSO funding are expected to design programs with input from individuals with lived expertise and ensure access and outcomes in program performance.
- c. Competencies for Working with People Experiencing Homelessness: The Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) has published needed competencies in the areas of knowledge, skills, and attitudes which are necessary to provide effective services for individuals at-risk of, or experiencing, homelessness. A full description of competencies, theoretical frameworks, and corresponding practices can be found on the [Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration \(SAMHSA\) website](#).
- d. Collaboration with the Community: Supportive of a community response to connect participants to culturally appropriate services, mainstream resources, services not provided by the awardee, and a supportive social network to support sufficiency, the awardee will work collaboratively with other nonprofits, community groups, community programs, and governmental partners to address participants' needs and unique vulnerabilities.

D. Specific Invoice Requirements

HSO utilizes the online contracting database called [PartnerGrants](#) for all contract claims, performance reporting and other contract requirements. For questions regarding invoices/payments, Operators are to contact the HSO Contract Manager.

E. Designation of Key Personnel

The City and the Operator resolve to keep the same key personnel assigned to this engagement throughout its term. In the event that it becomes necessary for the Operator to replace any key personnel, the replacement will be an individual having equivalent experience and competence in executing projects such as the one described herein. Additionally, the Operator shall promptly notify the City and obtain approval for the replacement; such approval shall not be unreasonably withheld. For the purposes of this solicitation, all questions and comments must go to the solicitation point of contact: HSDCompetitions@austintexas.gov.

F. Application Format and Submission Requirements

See Exhibit A: Standard Solicitation Provisions and Instructions for all requirements.

The Application must be submitted in the [Partnergrants database](#). No late submissions will be accepted. Responses should be included for each question.

Please note: Only name your uploaded documents with letters and numbers. To reduce possible submission and/or review delays, please ensure any attached file from your local drive DOES NOT contain any special characters. Letters and numbers are acceptable.

Applicant Registration

1. Confirm your organization is a registered vendor with the City of Austin.
 - To find the City of Austin Vendor Number please visit [Austin Finance Online](#) and search for the organization's legal name.

Austin Homeless Strategies and Operations
HSO Request For Application (RFA) 2026-001
South Austin Housing Navigation Center Operation and Social Services

- To register to become a potential City of Austin vendor, go to Austin Finance Online to register.
2. Be a registered user in the Partnergrants system. The proposals will be submitted through this web-based system.
- To register, visit Partnergrants and click on “Register Here.”
 - Note that the organization’s City of Austin Vendor number is required to complete registration in Partnergrants.